



**FITNESSWISE**

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# The performance mirror

Why **visualising** training data makes athletes smarter and more effective.

**W**e all struggle to trust the process and protocols in place, especially when it comes to number crunching. We normally force ourselves to trust it. However, it's important to not just trust it; you have to visualise it.

Having seen many world-class sports personalities over the years, they all have a process in place that makes things visual and quantifiable. This has helped them become icons of the game, especially in India. Many outside the domain would call it a superstition; nevertheless, the players call it a process for success, which they have proved time and again.

For example, a weekly log was introduced for the Indian cricket team to track their fitness sessions. Over the months, it became a tool for them to visibly see huge traction in numbers, and the rest is history — winning the World Cup and Champions Trophy.

Every player could crunch numbers per week in tandem with their fitness. As the season went on and the World Cup drew near, it started to click. The fitness score grew bigger and bigger each week, representing all the positive things each one had done throughout the season. It was a reminder of all the hard work, of how they showed up every day, and why they belonged on the Indian World Cup team. It wasn't a burden to put in the hard yards; it

was their superpower.

And that's precisely what your training data can be when you use it the right way — a visible, inclusive record of the work one has done. Your own personal scorecard, but with a lot more information conveniently stored in your pocket instead (thanks to technology!).

## **The psychology behind visualisation**

When I worked with a sports psychologist, I had to do a similar exercise as a coach. Initially, instead of logs, I had to pen down three things I did every day that contributed to training the players. It's no coincidence that later that year, I finally ended my five-year coaching drought by improving player performance and helping them represent the country and become iconic players. The players bought into the process through autosuggestion and regular note-taking, a concept I learned from the sports psychologist.

The idea that seeing your work helps you perform better isn't just circumstantial. Much research across neuroscience and sports science suggests that our brains process visual information efficiently, making it easier to recognise patterns and make decisions, whether you're building fitness or digging yourself into a ditch.

In sport-specific research, self-monitoring has been linked to better training outcomes. Studies in

competitive athletes found that a self-monitoring approach improved training behaviours and intensity accuracy. Fundamentally, athletes got better at executing workouts correctly.

There's also evidence that visual performance feedback, such as seeing pace, power, or heart rate against a target, helps athletes regulate effort and pacing more accurately, especially when fatigue would usually pull them off script. Knowing when to push and when to pull back becomes easier.

## **Using technology to take it a step further**

While using a log and writing notes can help you see all the work you've done, there are apps that can make visualisation even more impactful.

Instead of relying only on memory or how you felt, your training becomes something you can actually point to: what you planned versus what you completed, how your days and weeks are stacking up, and whether there is progression or regression. When progress is observable, it's easier to interpret and have confidence in.

## **Work for and against you**

Not every workout can be a home run. Sometimes they go exceptionally well, and other times they go devastatingly abysmal.

It's easy to chalk up a poor workout and not think too much about what caused it. But once you